

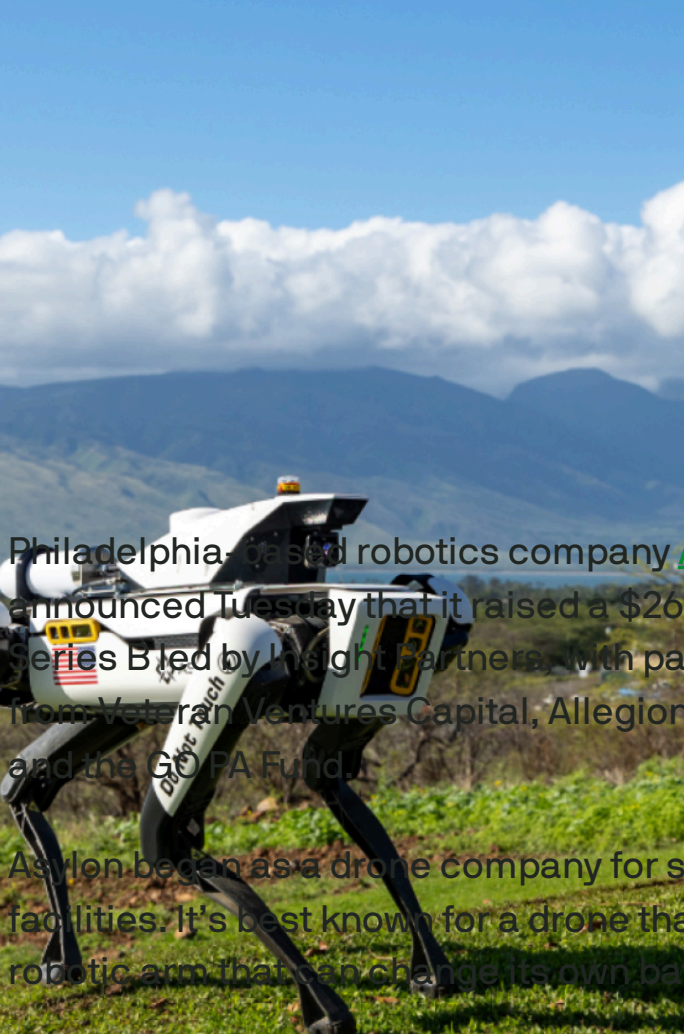
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STARTUPS



## Robot guard dogs help Asylon raise a \$26M Series B



Philadelphia-based robotics company [Asylon](#) announced Tuesday that it raised a \$26 million Series B led by Insight Partners, with participation from Veteran Ventures Capital, Allegion Ventures, and the GO PA Fund.

Asylon began as a drone company for securing facilities. It's best known for a drone that has a robotic arm that can change its own batteries.

But it also has a robotic guard dog service called DroneDog. Asylon takes the famed Boston Dynamics robot dog Spot and modifies it for guard work and to integrate with its command-and-control Guardian software. Asylon offers the drones, dogs, and software as its robotic security as a service (RaaS).

A site can be secured with ground patrols via robot dogs and flying cameras that cover more areas than stationary cameras. DroneDogs [can be sent to places unsafe](#) for humans or real dogs. And they can perform almost dog sniffing-like tasks such as detecting gas leaks or dangerous chemicals.

The company, which was founded in 2015, hasn't raised much venture capital prior to this compared with other drone and robotics companies. It previously raised about \$21 million, plus some government grants, bringing its total raised to about \$45 million, founder CEO Damon Henry told TechCrunch.

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While Henry described fundraising as hard, after the killing of UnitedHealthcare CEO Brian Thompson in December, companies have increased spending [on CEO home and facility security](#), such as DroneDog. Its RaaS can cost about \$100,000 to \$150,000 a year — akin to hiring a human bodyguard service.

“I went to an event last summer, a New York Tech Week event, and I happen to have met every investor that’s in the round at that event,” Henry said. When he decided to raise, he already had warm intros with investors who were aware that security spending is rising.

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Henry and his two co-founders, Adam Mohamed (CTO) and Brent McLaughlin (COO), were dorm roommates at MIT. But unlike the classic Silicon Valley story, they did not drop out. They went to work as aerospace engineers after graduation for companies like GE Aviation, Boeing, and Johns Hopkins Applied Physics Laboratory.

In 2015, the three friends saw Amazon announce its drone delivery service and were inspired. They quit their jobs and founded Asylon. By 2019 they had their first customer: Ford.

And in 2021, the startup almost suffered a swift death. Ford had agreed to let them do a live demo event showing how their drones worked at its facility. A group of Fortune 500 had signed up to see the demo, Henry recalled.

The night before the event, the drone crashed and was destroyed. Henry saw his company flash before his eyes: a ruined reputation. No customers. The end.

A dedicated employee drove all night to deliver another drone, but the founders had precious little time to get it running. Miraculously, they did, and it worked flawlessly during the event.

“The system flew consistently, perfectly all day long,” he said. “It won us our next three customers — Fortune 500 customers. And then the same day simultaneously, we actually won our first DoD contract for the drones.”

The founders have been carefully growing the company ever since. Asylon now employs 65 and has systems deployed in 15 states, he said.

Topics: [autonomous robots](#) [drones](#) [Insight Partners](#)

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IMAGE CREDITS: B GARAGE

HARDWARE



## B Garage raises \$20M for its warehouse inventory drones

Kate Park — 2:55 AM PDT · June 29, 2023

**B Garage**, a San Jose-based startup building autonomous drones along with software to track warehouse inventory, said today that it has picked up \$20 million in a Series A round of funding.

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New investor LB Investment led the Series A funding with participation from Ignite Innovation Fund, Krossroad Partners and existing backer SoftBank Ventures Asia. The proceeds, which bring the total amount raised by B Garage to \$30 million, will enable the outfit to further develop and commercialize its drones and grow its engineering and business teams.

The startup was founded in 2017 by Aiden Kim, a former software engineer at Oracle. Kim, who holds a PhD in aeronautics and astronautics from

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learned from the industry experts at the time was that industries like agriculture and logistics faced labor shortages, Kim told TechCrunch.

“[Most] B2B logistics warehouses in the U.S. are far from urban areas and face a severe labor shortage,” Kim said. “The autonomous drone technology could be highly suitable for B2B logistics warehouse inventory management.”

B Garage's mission is to address the labor shortage issue in those sectors by utilizing artificial intelligence and autonomous technology.





The company has worked on a proof-of-concept pilot test with [Kenco Innovation Lab](#), a unit of Kenco Logistics, for the last few months. Now it is planning to deploy its drones to more than 10 select Kenco warehouses across the U.S. by the end of 2023. It is also working with [Incheon Port Authority](#) in South Korea, aiming to commence the project by the year-end.



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Companies like [Verity](#), [Gather AI](#) and [Corvus Robotics](#) have also raised funding for their inventory drones. B Garage has tried to set itself apart from its rivals with four features: full autonomy that covers multiple aisles, no additional infrastructure required, mapping-free operation and automatic battery swapping.

B Garage's drone can "navigate through multiple aisles, providing comprehensive coverage of warehouse spaces," Kim said, adding that many other drone solutions are limited to specific paths or single aisles.

On top of that, users don't need to integrate additional technology to operate drones with their warehouse infrastructure



IMAGE CREDITS:

CEO OF B GARAGE, AIDEN KIM

e, so there are no extra charges. Competitors typically require an initial fee and ongoing operating costs for installing markers or beacons (indoor GPS) throughout the logistics warehouse and regularly updating the mapping, the CEO explained.

Another differentiator, the startup claims, is the automatic battery swapping facility.

“Our drones are equipped with advanced battery technology that enables efficient battery replacement,” Kim continued. If the drone’s battery runs out, the drone automatically returns to its dedicated battery swapping station, which replaces the depleted battery with a fully charged one from its inventory of pre-charged batteries in a matter of minutes.

B Garage plans to continue enhancing its software solutions with the goal of integrating with its hardware to apply its technology to industries beyond logistics, such as defense and security, according to the company.

It also aims to introduce ground robots for inventory management, Kim said when asked about its plans. The ground robots will allow the startup to cater to a broader range of customers, providing comprehensive solutions for inventory



management across various sectors, Kim explained.

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**Kate Park**

Reporter, Asia | [X](#)

Kate Park is a reporter at TechCrunch, with a focus on technology, startups and venture capital in Asia. She...

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Drone startup Aptonomy introduces the self-flying security guard



[Aptonomy Inc.](#) has developed drone technology that could make prison breaks, robberies or malicious intrusions of any kind impossible for mere mortals.

Dubbing it a kind of “flying security guard,” the company has built its systems on top of a drone often used by movie-makers, the [DJI S-1000+](#), a camera-carrying octocopter.

To that skeleton, Aptonomy adds a new flight controller, and second computer to power day- and night-vision cameras, bright lights, and loudspeakers, among other things.

IMAGE CREDITS: [APTONOMY INC.](#)  
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And more importantly than the hardware features, Aptonomy has developed artificial intelligence and navigational systems that allow its drones to fly low and fast, avoiding obstacles in structure-dense environments, and detecting human activity or faces in the area, autonomously.

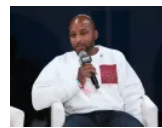
A user can open up a browser, get onto the Aptonomy interface, click on a point on a map to send out a drone to a particular location, then watch that flight in real time, or review a recording of it later.

Aptonomy’s drones can be programmed to fly wherever a motion detector transmits data suggesting unusual activity on the ground, as well.

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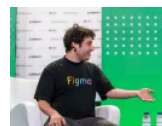
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The drones are not just self-flying. When their batteries are running low, they fly back to a charging station to power up.



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Aptonomy co-founders [Mihail Pivtoraiko](#) and [Siddharth Sanan](#) are well-known in the industry already. Both attained doctorates from the Robotics Institute at Carnegie Mellon University prior to starting Aptonomy.

Pivtoraiko previously worked at NASA, Jet Propulsion Laboratory, Lockheed Martin and Intel. And Sanan's soft robotics and human-robot safety research was the inspiration behind the robot Baymax in Disney's [Big Hero 6](#).

The duo is part of the current [Y Combinator](#) batch of startups, and have raised some seed funding through the accelerator.

They explained that most unmanned aerial systems in commercial use are being used from hundreds of feet in the air to do things like thermal or

topographic mapping at this point. But those drones can't perceive human faces, like security guards must.

Meanwhile, prosumer camera drones that fly lower don't have the motion controls and perception required to navigate safely, and without a human pilot, around complex environments like a nuclear power plant, cell towers or a supermax prison.

Aptonomy's drones rove over a set area, and can be accessed by a guard who is hundreds or thousands of miles away.

They can record suspicious activity, shine a light on intruders, allow two-way communication with the intruder through loudspeakers, and generally scare off potential troublemakers as an intimidating presence in the air.

One energy company has preordered Aptonomy's drones to use at oil refineries this year. "Refineries are in remote locations and are very hard for human security guards to patrol. But they are a target for attacks," Pivtoraiko noted.

The startup believes that businesses with lots of infrastructure-related assets will want to use their drones to supplement, or even replace, their human patrols.

One thing businesses with deep security concerns will like most about Aptonomy's drones, Sanan said, is that they can be programmed to approach intruders in a way that is compliant with all relevant laws and protocols.

That involves shining a light, recording if possible, and using your voice before ever approaching an intruder, physically, or before escalating to physically stop him or her.

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Lora Kolodny was emerging technologies editor and video host at TechCrunch.

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